> another form of imperial adulation. *But I am suggesting that it was under the British that 'caste' became a single term capable of expressing, organizing, and above all 'systematizing' India's diverse forms of social identity, community, and organization. This was achieved through an identifiable (if contested) ideological canon as the result of a concrete encounter with colonial modernity during two hundred years of British domination. In short, colonialism made caste what it is today*. It produced the conditions that made possible the opening lines of this book, by making caste the central symbol of Indian society… [emphases added].

While the book's focus on the colonial creation of 'caste' makes it a must-read, what is of relevance to the discussion at hand is Dirks' unequivocal and extensive identification of the role of Christian missionaries as the British coloniser's go-to ethnographers of Bharat and how they saw the 'caste system', in particular Brahmins, as the chief impediment to the Christianisation of Bharat. In this regard, he cites the influential work of French Catholic missionary Abbe Dubois, titled *Description of the Character, Manners, and Customs of the People of India, and of Their Institutions, Religious and Civil*, which was published in 1816. This book was treated as the most comprehensive authority on the caste system, so much so that the Madras government bought the copyright for the book from Dubois for a fortune, which provided him with a source of regular pension for years. In fact, William Bentinck, the then Governor of Madras, showered effusive praise on Dubois' work. Following are Dirks' views on the 'anthropological service' provided by Dubois to the British administration in Bharat and its use for the purpose of conversion[23]:

> Dubois performed an anthropological service to the British rulers of India, doing so in part because as a French Jesuit missionary he was thought to be able to cross social worlds far more readily than the imperial British themselves. *But, as was true with all missionary perspectives, social worlds were crossed in order to convert souls, a social fact that led to very strong views on the subject of caste.*
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> …. As we shall see, much early 'colonial' ethnography was in fact written by missionaries, who observed Indian society more closely than did British officials, but experienced it in relation to their primary